

Chapter 4 - Embrace

After hearing the calls from below, Ning Fuyi also looked up. The moment she saw that person, despite her reluctance, she couldn't help but hold her breath.

The woman stood steadily outside the door. Wind rushed in, lifting her petal-like layered skirt. Her cloak fluttered on her shoulders, tangling with her hair. The pure white Flying Feather Rope that had just been recalled was tied around her waist, outlining the curves of her figure, adding a touch of gentle beauty to her ever-present divine venerable aura.

"Divine Venerable, Divine Venerable..." The two men outside the door tremblingly tried to block her, but with just a blink from Chu Qingqiu, their bodies suddenly stiffened and fell like stone sculptures.

Two thuds echoed, making everyone present shudder for an instant.

Ning Fuyi realized she had been staring at her in fascination and quickly pinched herself, pulling her gaze away.

No matter how unparalleled her elegance, she was still Chu Qingqiu—Chu Qingqiu with a heart harder than stone. Ning Fuyi repeated this phrase to herself twice before calming her emotions.

She had already fallen into hell once; she didn't want to do it again.

Mei Chengshou beside her clearly hadn't expected Chu Qingqiu to appear here either. His gaze kept shifting between the Foundation Stone and Chu Qingqiu. Finally, his beard trembled as he forced out a smile.

"Divine Venerable Chu Ling, it's been a long time. I was merely disciplining a junior disciple—how embarrassing for you to witness this. However, the sect has important matters today. I wonder what brings the Divine Venerable here?" He made small talk hypocritically, pretending not to see the two guardians Chu Qingqiu had knocked down.

Chu Qingqiu glanced at him but didn't speak. Instead, she walked into the great hall with her hands behind her back. The doors slowly closed again, and the wind throughout the hall finally ceased.

She walked without sound, but each step matched the heartbeats of everyone present, drumming rhythmically. Hundreds of disciples dared not make a sound, only holding their breath and lowering their heads.

From the ninth heaven above to the underworld below, who didn't know that Chu Ling, Chu Qingqiu, was one of the cultivation world's most exceptional talents? No one knew her origins. The world only knew that a thousand years ago, during a great battle, she and Condensing Heaven Sect Master Ning Changfeng appeared together, eradicating the ancient evil spirit that had plagued the mortal realm—something even the Penglai Realm¹ couldn't handle.

From then on, her name echoed throughout the six realms.

Back then, the four great families and five major sects all tried to recruit them both. However, neither accepted a single invitation. One came to Cloud Ascension Mountain to establish the Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate, while the other retreated to Purple Cloud Peak, rarely seen by the world.

Thus, two thousand years had passed.

So Chu Qingqiu's appearance here today was a shock to everyone.

Mei Chengshou received no response, and his previously glowing complexion paled a few shades. Yet he didn't dare lose his temper, so he coughed a few times to cover his embarrassment before asking again: "Divine Venerable Chu Ling..."

"What, is the Immortal Venerable not welcoming?" Chu Qingqiu approached the high platform and spoke slowly, interrupting Mei Chengshou's words.

Mei Chengshou was stunned for a moment, then quickly smiled apologetically: "Welcome, of course we welcome the Divine Venerable's visit to our mountain gate. However, today is an important day for our sect. Perhaps the Divine Venerable could wait in the rear hall, and after our ceremony concludes, this humble one will properly receive you."

Chu Qingqiu looked up indifferently, her expression unchanged: "No need for reception. However, Changfeng and I have an agreement—there's nowhere in this sect I cannot go, so I won't trouble myself with the rear hall."

"Please continue, Immortal Venerable." She raised her hand slightly, gesturing for Mei Chengshou to proceed while a rattan chair appeared behind her, and she sat down properly.

Up close, Mei Chengshou's beard had turned several shades whiter from anger.

Ning Fuyi smiled with satisfaction.

Though she didn't know what Chu Qingqiu was plotting, this move was beneficial to her, so she said nothing more. Instead, she seized this opportunity, stepped forward, and placed her palm on the Foundation Stone.

The Chief Elder cried out in surprise. The originally ink-black Foundation Stone suddenly turned bright red, like a red-hot iron. But in the next second, the Foundation Stone gradually took on a golden hue, and finally, it emitted brilliant, universal golden light that dimmed even the sunlight.

"How could this be..." the elder said tremblingly. The others below were also shocked and began talking, making the hall buzz like a beehive.

The Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate's rule was that after a sect master's death, only those recognized by the Foundation Stone could succeed as the next sect master. Recognition by the Foundation Stone was manifested by the emission of golden light.

It was well known that Ning Fuyi had mediocre talent and no natural gifts, so she definitely wouldn't be chosen as sect master. This matter was therefore quite strange.

Mei Chengshou's face had turned as white as if he'd been dead for three days, with only his mouth red from biting out blood in frustration.

"Master Uncle Mei should have had the same effect just now." Ning Fuyi looked innocently naive as she raised her hand, turning with a smile. "But Master Uncle shouldn't misunderstand—this disciple doesn't mean to imply you tampered with anything. Perhaps this Foundation Stone is just old and has some problems."

Hearing Ning Fuyi's sarcasm, Mei Chengshou's gaze wanted to tear her into pieces, but with everyone present, especially Chu Qingqiu sitting below, he didn't dare act rashly.

He could only swallow his broken teeth.

"This old man will try." The elder holding the Foundation Stone said tremblingly, then slowly extended his withered hand to touch the surface of the stone that had returned to black.

Under the burning gazes of everyone below, the Foundation Stone remained silent for a while, then once again displayed brilliant golden light.

Discussion erupted throughout the great hall again. Mei Chengshou's hands behind his back showed bulging veins. Just as he was about to say something, the purple-robed female elder who had rebuked Ning Fuyi earlier suddenly stepped forward and bowed.

"Immortal Venerable Mei, according to Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate's rules, only the Foundation Stone can decide the sect master's succession. However, today the Foundation Stone behaves strangely. We need to examine and repair it before proceeding with the ceremony. Please understand, Immortal Venerable."

The woman had a stern, righteous face, wearing dark purple robes with a circle of dark silver ornaments on her head, looking naturally imposing.

"Elder Pingyao." Mei Chengshou returned the bow without raising his head, smiling lightly. "Sect Master Condensing Heaven's sudden passing caught us off guard, and the once-in-a-century Zhaoyao Conference² is imminent. When the six sects compete and Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate is leaderless, we'll surely suffer afterward."

"But..." Elder Pingyao wanted to say more but was interrupted by Mei Chengshou, who blocked her next words.

"I originally didn't want to reveal this, but since the Foundation Stone is now problematic, for the sect's stability, I must speak." Mei Chengshou shook his head. His right palm opened, and golden light flashed, revealing a piece of turtle shell.

The turtle shell was carved with magnificent golden patterns that didn't seem to be ordinary script. Mei Chengshou stepped forward and handed the turtle shell to Elder Pingyao. She accepted it dubiously, and after examining it, her eyes widened in shock.

"This is a token from the Penglai Realm." Elder Pingyao turned to pass the turtle shell to other elders for examination. Everyone who handled it showed grave expressions.

Ning Fuyi had never known Mei Chengshou possessed such a trump card. She frowned at him, thinking this was bad.

Apart from hermit masters and scattered immortals, the cultivation world's main powers were the four great families, six major sects, and the Penglai Realm far beyond the Eastern Sea. As the most ancient immortal mountain, the Penglai Realm had been the leader of the immortal world tens of thousands of years ago. Only after aristocratic families and sects rose in the martial world did they develop a "mind our own business" attitude.

Now they suddenly wanted to interfere in Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate's affairs—what was their intention?

The elders looked at each other, momentarily speechless.

"Do the elders have any other teachings?" Seeing the turtle shell's effect, Mei Chengshou showed a satisfied smile. "If not, let's not delay further. Stabilizing the situation early is what matters."

With that, he turned to the Chief Elder and said sternly: "Elder, let us continue."

He suddenly summoned the Foundation Stone before him, half-floating in the air, raising his palm to touch it. Ning Fuyi knew she absolutely couldn't let him succeed. Her eyes flashed with murderous intent as she summoned her immortal power with both hands, preparing to step forward and stop him.

However, as soon as she took a step, a calm voice came from below the platform, halting her movement.

"Immortal Venerable Mei, please wait." Chu Qingqiu, who had been watching from the sidelines, had somehow already stood up. She lightly touched the ground with her toes and gracefully appeared on the platform, standing steadily with her hands behind her back.

"What matter does Divine Venerable Chu Ling have now?" Every time he was interrupted at a crucial moment, Mei Chengshou clenched his outstretched hand, suppressing his anger as he looked at Chu Qingqiu. "If the Divine Venerable has doubts, you might ask the Penglai Realm for clarification."

"The Immortal Venerable jokes. Chu Ling doesn't doubt anything—I merely have something to announce." Chu Qingqiu showed no expression between her brows, but that imposing presence was intimidating enough that people dared not look directly at her.

Her delicate hand turned, and suddenly a piece of cloud brocade appeared in her palm, bearing a few sparse characters with a signature stamped with a bold, unrestrained seal.

That seal was bold and flowing—clearly Ning Changfeng's.

"It's the Sect Master's handwriting." Elder Pingyao said in surprise. The other elders also recognized Ning Changfeng's calligraphy and looked at each other.

"Divine Venerable, may this humble one examine it?" Another white-bearded elder stepped forward cautiously, then took the cloud brocade from Chu Qingqiu's hands and looked down carefully.

"This is indeed the Sect Master's handwriting. It says she requests Divine Venerable Chu Ling to take over Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate." The elder stroked his beard, turning to look at the other elders' expressions. Everyone was momentarily troubled.

Mei Chengshou was shocked, frowning as he spoke: "The Divine Venerable has always devoted herself to cultivation and worldly affairs. Being sect master would require considerable energy. The Divine Venerable should think carefully. Moreover, the Penglai Realm's intentions..."

"This is Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate, not Penglai." Chu Qingqiu said lightly. She turned toward the Foundation Stone, her robes brushing past Ning Fuyi elegantly, leaving behind a refreshing fragrance.

Ning Fuyi's vision blurred for an instant.

"I usually dislike many affairs and don't wish to trouble you. But since this is Ning Changfeng's dying wish, I cannot refuse. So for the position of sect master, you and I will serve jointly."

With that, without waiting for Mei Chengshou to speak, she placed her palm on the Foundation Stone. Golden ancient characters instantly appeared above the stone, as if invisible hands were writing. The ceremony was nearly complete.

Mei Chengshou beside her nearly fainted from anger. But since Chu Qingqiu had acted first and he didn't dare openly oppose her, he could only compromise. With a dark expression, he added his own palm, managing to carve his name into the Foundation Stone before the ceremony concluded.

When the last stroke was completed, the succession ceremony ended. Everyone else, awed by Chu Qingqiu's power, dared not say a word.

"Since this matter is concluded, I won't stay longer. Farewell."

After Chu Qingqiu spoke, she leaped down from the high platform and walked gracefully through the crowd. Everyone below stepped aside, making way for her.

Her flying robe disappeared into the brilliant sunlight outside the door, followed by a thunderous sound as the great doors closed.

The great hall, which had been silent as death, gradually became noisy. The disciples who hadn't dared breathe finally began discussing, creating a clamor.

"I'm not dreaming, am I? Divine Venerable Chu Ling will be our sect master from now on?" someone exclaimed shrilly.

"The rumors about Divine Venerable Chu Ling being cold and heartless are really true. When she passed by just now, I felt like I was frozen. Look, my palms are still cold now." someone said anxiously.

Others gossiped: "The Divine Venerable actually agreed to the Sect Master's request. Their relationship really is unusual..."

"Shh... don't spread idle gossip!" A man with sword-like eyebrows and starry eyes sternly rebuked them. Only then did the commotion in the hall subside somewhat.

Ning Fuyi ignored the others' chatter and paid no more attention to the fuming Mei Chengshou beside her. She frowned, looking in the direction Chu Qingqiu had left, completely puzzled.

In her previous life, she had begged Chu Qingqiu for so long, yet she never even glanced at her mother. What was different about this life? Not only had she appeared at Cloud Ascension Mountain Gate, but she had also agreed to take over as sect master?

Could it be... Ning Fuyi had a flash of inspiration. Her body moved faster than her thoughts. Ignoring Liu Wenzhu's calls beside her, she rushed out of Cloud Deep Hall at top speed.

"Chu Qingqiu, stop!" Ning Fuyi called loudly.

Outside the hall, a long winding path stretched ahead. At its end stood a pure white figure, blending with the ink-wash mountains behind her like a fairy from a painting.

Seemingly hearing her call, Chu Qingqiu slowly turned around, standing with her hands behind her back in the heavenly light.

"Chu Qingqiu, you..."

Ning Fuyi didn't finish her words because her vision suddenly darkened as if ink had been splashed across it.

The excruciating pain of having all her strength drained suddenly coursed through her entire body. Ning Fuyi involuntarily fell forward, and Chu Qingqiu's frowning face suddenly came closer in her vision.

Ning Fuyi instinctively cursed. She was the thoroughly evil, unrepentantly wicked first demon king of all four seas and eight wastelands³—even if she fell, she had to keep her spine straight and absolutely couldn't collapse at Chu Qingqiu's feet!

So she used her last bit of strength to charge forward aggressively for two more steps.

And crashed headfirst into Chu Qingqiu's embrace.

Footnotes:

¹ **Penglai Realm (蓬莱境)** - In Chinese mythology, Penglai is one of the legendary mountains of the immortals, located in the Eastern Sea. In cultivation novels, it typically represents the most ancient and powerful immortal sect or realm.

² **Zhaoyao Conference (招摇大会)** - A gathering of the major cultivation sects, likely for competitions, exchanges, or important announcements. "Zhaoyao" can mean "swaggering" or "ostentatious."

³ **Four seas and eight wastelands (四海八荒)** - A classical Chinese expression meaning "the entire world" or "everywhere under heaven." It encompasses all directions and vast territories, emphasizing the scope of one's power or influence.